

by the Ionians.⁴ Any one who examines will find that the Persian names, one and all without exception, end with this letter.⁵

140. Thus much I can declare of the Persians with entire certainty, from my own actual knowledge. There is another custom which is spoken of with reserve, and not openly, concerning their dead. It is said that the body of a male Persian is never buried, until it has been torn either by a dog or a bird of prey.⁶ That the Magi have this custom is beyond a doubt, for they practise it without any concealment. The dead bodies are covered with wax, and then buried in the ground.

The Magi are a very peculiar race, differing entirely from the Egyptian priests, and indeed from all other men whatsoever. The Egyptian priests make it a point of religion not to kill any live animals except those which they offer in sacrifice. The Magi, on the contrary, kill animals of all kinds with their own hands, excepting dogs⁷ and men. They even seem to take a delight in the employment, and kill, as readily as they do other animals, ants and snakes, and such like flying or creeping things. However, since this has always been their custom, let them keep to it. I return to my former narrative.

141. Immediately after the conquest of Lydia by the Persians, the Ionian and Æolian Greeks sent ambassadors to Cyrus at Sardis, and prayed to become his lieges on the footing which

the same time it held the place of *san* in the alphabet. (See Bunsen's *Philosophy of Univ. Hist.* vol. i. p. 258.)

⁶ Here Herodotus was again mistaken. The Persian names of men which terminate with a consonant end indeed invariably with the letter *s*, or rather *sh*, as *Kurúsh* (Cyrus), *Dáryavush* (Darius), *Chishpáish* (Teispes), *Hakhámanish*, &c. (Achæmenes). [The *sh* in such cases is the mere nominative ending of the 2nd and 3rd declensions; *i. e.* of themes ending in *i* and *u*.—H. C. R.] But a large number of Persian names of men were pronounced with a vowel termination, not expressed in writing, and in these the last consonant might be almost any letter. We find on the monuments *Vashtásp(a)* Hystaspes—*Arshám(a)* Arsames—*Ariyáraman(a)* Ariaramnes—*Bardi(a)* Bardius or Smerdis—*Gaum(a)* Gomates—*Gaubru(a)* Gobryas—&c. &c. The *sigma* in these cases is a mere conventional addition of the Greeks.

⁶ Agathias (ii. p. 60) and Strabo (xv. p. 1042) also mention this strange custom, which still prevails among the Parsees wherever they are found, whether in Persia or in India. Chardin relates that there was in his time a cemetery, half a league from Isfahán, consisting of a round tower 35 feet high, without any doorway or other entrance. Here the Guebres deposited their dead by means of a ladder, and left them to be devoured by the crows, which were to be seen in large numbers about the place. (*Voyage en Perse*, tom. ii. p. 186.) Such towers exist throughout India, wherever the Parsees are numerous. The bodies are laid on iron bars sloping inwards. When the flesh is gone, the bones slip through between the bars, or sliding down them fall in at the centre, where there is an open space left for the purpose.

⁷ The dog is represented in the Zendavesta as the special animal of Ormazd, and is still regarded with peculiar reverence by the Parsees. On one of the magnificent tombs at the Chehl-Minâr, of which Chardin has given an accurate drawing (plate 68), a row of dogs is the ornament of the entablature.